
Commentary

Learning to Support Improvement—Next Steps for Research on District Practice

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Research on the district's role in fostering improvements affecting student learning is still in its infancy. Since the early 1990s, when school districts were often viewed as a waste of time and money (Chubb and Moe 1990), the winds have shifted, with states and districts expected to promote coherence and accountability in the loosely coupled U.S. school system (Boyd and Crowson 1981). The articles in this issue not only expand middle-level theories concerning how these enlarged responsibilities and roles may develop but also add empirical meat to expectations in state and federal accountability policies. As advertised, the articles represent a "first installment" on a needed scholarly dialogue. Let me further the dialogue by suggesting topics for additional investigation arising from their work.

Theories, District Roles, and the Problem of Change

Learning theories presume a social object that is changing. The collective learning theories undergirding these articles assume that incremental changes most likely occur when people encounter stimuli causing them to reflect and make adjustments in sustained group settings. The link between collective learning theories and organizational change theories rests on studies showing positive organizational outcomes accruing from weakly coordinated change efforts (e.g., when people "muddle through" in a "garbage can" environment where goals, participants, and suitable actions are unclear; Lindblom 1959; March and Olsen 1976). The authors in this issue apparently agree that, for district leaders and central offices to become potent actors in school improve-

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ment, they must transcend the myth of strategic, top-down planning and embrace the complexity of becoming learners.

The articles by Honig (2008, in this issue), Stein and Coburn (2008, in this issue), and Gallucci (2008, in this issue) represent a major shift in assumptions about how change occurs, away from prescription and planning and toward ambiguity. Honig, for example, emphasizes the uncertain conditions that districts face as they attempt to change; Stein and Coburn show that varied (if undiscussed) theories of action underlie how districts approach network development; and Gallucci's article demonstrates that, to persist in an extended learning space, participants may need high levels of tolerance for not knowing.

This is useful theory. Yet current policy language and many scholarly investigations, emphasizing alignment of purpose and practice, presume that change should be strategic and guided by leader-directed collective vision and that the district is responsible for making change happen—even when policy emanates from federal or state legislatures (Anderson 2003; Fuhrman and Elmore 2004). In such environments, districts and schools may feel that they have been mandated to learn—a tension implicitly acknowledged by all the authors.

Images of School Organization—and Their Alternatives

Reflecting the “zoning” of educational work, research on innovation, change, and learning often constructs incomplete pictures of how school organizations influence student development. Thus, research on teaching and teacher learning typically pays little or no attention to the work environment beyond the classroom, other than relationships with colleagues or coaches. Research on principals, particularly on their instructional leadership, ignores the district office and community and even the variability of classrooms and teachers within a building. Similarly, research on districts often focuses on the superintendency rather than on the relationship between the central office and schools.

These articles are an exception. Especially noteworthy, the articles cross disciplinary boundaries and perspectives, although the authors' prior knowl-

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edge and research traditions still shape how they define the “problem of learning” and pose research questions, thereby affirming the value of collaborative research that does not demand consensus around theory or method.

Networks, Bureaucracies, or Both?

All of the authors emphasize unpredictable aspects of structure and relationships in complex, medium-to-large districts. Appropriately, they consider the significant role of networks and practice communities in educational improvement.¹ In addition, the authors highlight the inattention of social learning theories to effects of formal structures on learning environments. Learning theories are not necessarily incompatible with structural theories: witness how “architecture” and opportunities that districts provide or deny can shape informal networks, which, in turn, become communities of practice that influence the formal structure of roles and responsibilities (Stein and Coburn 2008, in this issue). Similarly, individual learning connects to the characteristics of school and its leadership (Gallucci 2008, in this issue). Additional attention to both structure and relationships within the same research analysis will push learning theories beyond their current focus on process(ing) and will help organizational and sociocultural learning theories move beyond “micropolitics.”

Inside the District Office: Who Is Doing What?

More than previous research, these articles illuminate how districts work with schools and how these relationships are developed, sustained, or stunted. Yet their emphasis on helping/assisting relationships reflects only one side of the distinction between administrators who do and do not have supervisory authority. The former (“real administrators”) make binding decisions and take heat from the school board and community. The latter (e.g., who run professional development or other special programs) are marginal to the power structure. These technical assistance newcomers may find it difficult to connect with real administrators without sacrificing their primary connections with the field (Honig 2008, in this issue; Stein and Coburn 2008, in this issue). Gallucci’s analysis shows how the experiences of central office staff responsible for developing Vygotsky Spaces in elementary schools influenced district ideas about organizing professional development but stops short of revealing how this cross-pollination occurred.

More analysis of how interlinked communities of practice (Stein and Coburn 2008, in this issue) and district-school “assistance relationships” (Honig 2008,

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in this issue) fit into the larger picture of district role and power relations would extend this line of thinking productively. The circumstances under which quasi-independent communities are linked and influence one another will provide clues about how key decision makers learn (or do not) from the daily practice of people assisting instructional improvement in schools.

Role Compatibility or Role Conflict?

Social and legal expectations compound the problem of quasi-independent communities of practice within district offices. Simultaneous responsibility for regulation and assistance is both widespread and stressful in educational organizations,² an inherent organizational strain that in other public sectors (e.g., child welfare and environmental protection) has prompted discussions about “reinventing regulation” (Gormley 1999; Kraft and Scheberle 1998). Balancing multiple roles challenges districts that are expanding their assistance activities while simultaneously evaluating school performance in reaching state and district standards.

The authors point to boundary-spanning behaviors and negotiation of joint work to explain why relationships between schools and districts are more or less productive. Research needs to probe conditions that define, support, and protect effective technical assistance roles within the district office and schools and how people who do this work fit in the organization and develop networks of influence without being seen as “regulators.”

The Role of Emotion and Storytelling

While theoretical language is usually neutral in tone and affect, emotion and even passion are receiving increasing emphasis in educational theory (Hargreaves 2002; Palmer 1998) and in theories that attend to symbolism and meanings of “artifacts” and “boundary objects.” Gallucci’s findings that change is hard, artifacts are only preliminary outlines for change, and most teachers are deeply attached to their work illuminate emotional dimensions of organizational learning: relations were successful when leaders helped others develop a coherent story covering both the emotional and the professional meanings of the artifacts.

Storytelling reflects how people make sense of new experiences by building bridges between past practices and knowledge and future behaviors (Kruse and Louis, forthcoming). Telling and retelling the change story enables sharing and shaping of understanding, especially when key participants (e.g., principals) participate in the conversations (Stein and Coburn 2008, in this issue).

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More insight into how the creating and telling of change stories emerges from boundary-crossing communities of practice, under the influence of forces beyond their control, will deepen our grasp of organizational learning.

Environmental Complexity and District-School Relationships

While these articles begin to connect the dots between teachers' pedagogic learning, school-based professional community learning, and district learning, they say less about how these learning events reside in, and are affected by, the larger context of community, state, and nation. Ignoring the larger context that influences how learning occurs in different parts of organizations may result in silos of understanding.

Investigating all environmental connections is hard to imagine, but multiple layers of context clearly matter. For example, experienced superintendents' approach to school improvement in smaller districts is influenced by the policy culture and patterns of state authority in ways that state policy initiatives alone cannot explain (Anderson et al. 2008). Districts' access to resources reflects differences in their environment, creating differential access of teachers to networks of assistance and community (Achinstein et al. 2004).

Detailed qualitative studies of practice and learning in specific contexts (e.g., those in this issue's articles) are key to understanding collective learning. In short, how we organize for learning today may not work well in shifting environments. Understanding these shifts in learning and environment over time is central to good recommendations for both theory and practice.

Sustainable Relationships?

The transition from supervision, budget, and personnel management to active change agent roles is hard for districts, and many still flounder with multiple innovations that do not add up. We have long known that innovations die easily (e.g., Berman and McLaughlin 1978), and recent studies of long-term change have brought renewed attention to sustainability (Hargreaves 2006). The successful initiatives described in these articles beg for more investigation: many seem person dependent, in part because they involve building networks, and when a person occupying a key node in the network leaves, a busy learning system easily grinds down to a drone of perfunctory meetings.

While instability may naturally arise in the move from a bureaucratic to a network-focused organization, networks and communities of practice can be extremely resilient.³ We need to learn more about how districts navigate this

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tension, how new boundary-spanning roles can become more supple and durable in light of likely personnel turnover and environmental uncertainty.

Data-Based Decision Making or Knowledge Use?

The drive to ensure that all educators are data-based decision makers is palpable in the current reform zeitgeist.⁴ In both prescriptive and descriptive literature, data use is integrally connected to concepts of team or organizational learning, as is evident in administrator-initiated efforts to link the development of teacher professional communities and the use of data to address issues of student achievement (DuFour 2001). This prescriptive, top-down approach is far from an earlier view of teacher professional communities as organic, teacher-initiated collectives engaged in mutual exploration of problems of practice. The articles return to this original perspective. The concepts of organizational and sociocultural learning they present cannot be reduced to data-based decision making but instead imply knowledge creation as part of knowledge use.

Nonetheless, the ideas presented in these articles run the same risk as earlier research on professional community: they may be co-opted into a top-down agenda driven by pressures for quick solutions to new problems identified in schools, even though serious attempts to promote organizational and sociocultural learning require persistence in relationships over time. All too easily, districts may display collective “learning disabilities”—inattentiveness to new information, weak absorptive capacity (piling on innovations without determining their fit with existing practices), or precipitous rejection of ideas—which are common but often undiagnosed (Louis 1994).

We need to know more about how “outsiders” and district-based linking agents can support and maximize the learning of naturally emerging school-based groups that focus over time on instructional practice and student achievement (Kruse and Louis 2007). Examining districts’ work with schools might reveal how often and under what conditions districts do or do not revert to prescriptive, simple ideas about what constitutes “data” versus these articles’ expansive ideas about what constitutes a “knowledge base.” Such insights might help districts rethink their organization in order to improve knowledge acquisition, development, and use in schools.

A Final Contribution That Cannot Be Ignored

These articles span disciplinary boundaries and make sense of differences and similarities among approaches outlined by theorists who write in their own

silos. As an organizational sociologist, I have often had difficulty crediting contributions of sociocultural learning theorists, and psychologists have an equally difficult time with some organizationally focused learning theories. Together, these articles have made sense of theoretical concepts in ways that lead us toward more practical, nuanced suggestions about how people in real settings might be sensitized to different learning modalities. I look forward to reading further iterations of their work.

Notes

1. Recent research on noneducational organizations (e.g., Greenhalgh et al. 2004; Lee and Cole 2003; Thomas et al. 2001; Tsoukas and Chia 2002) further buttresses attention to networks and practice communities.
2. This includes state education agencies (which have been given new assistance and monitoring responsibilities in the last decade), intermediate service units (often funded by the state), and principals (who supervise and evaluate teachers but also are expected to be supportive instructional leaders; see Firestone and Wilson [1983] for one early analysis of this tension).
3. Lave and Wenger's (1991) example of Alcoholics Anonymous suggests that an organization with almost no employees, no formal membership requirements, and no rules has grown exponentially since its founding (79–83).
4. Teachers often do not use data in the way that administrators would like because they get the wrong information at the wrong time (Ingram et al. 2004). Districts have been scrambling to gather more useful information and make it more easily available, but this is still a major concern.

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